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## Epistemic constitution of lifted mechanical solidarity

**epistemic constitution of lifted mechanical solidarity** *noun phrase* **Status:** proposed synthetic term **Fields:** social epistemology, sociology of knowledge, sociology of morality, moral and political psychology, cultural theory, institutional design, argumentation theory

### Short explanation for busy readers

An **epistemic constitution of lifted mechanical solidarity** is the society-wide meta-order that governs how a plural modern society relates public life to truth. It determines which persons and institutions receive epistemic authority, what counts as admissible evidence, whether people may honestly express doubt and disagreement, how claims are publicly tested, how errors are corrected, how collective memory is preserved, and whether social belonging depends upon professing an authorized account of reality.

It is a **universally governing second-order order** and, under the single-slot principle, a **lifted full capture**. The shared binding force lies in rules that generate, select, apply, and revise concrete answers, not in one fixed catalogue of answers. Its generated outputs can include plural first-order jurisdictions; the persons, offices, professions, institutions, communities, and contracting parties beneath it can therefore remain differentiated and domain-limited even when the generator governs universally.

It is called **lifted mechanical solidarity** because citizens share an answer-generating meta-order. They can reach different first-order answers and live different religious, occupational, and personal lives while remaining bound by

how answers and authorities are produced and corrected. *Lifted* is a new extension of [Émile Durkheim's distinction between mechanical and organic solidarity](#); it is not Durkheim's own term.

The concept is analytically modular. It uses [Culture Mechanics](#) to describe one implementation of the shared order, but its central truth/systemic-lying distinction can be evaluated directly through public avowal, authority, evidence, disagreement, attention, memory, and correction.

The concept covers a tension space between two ideal-typical endpoints:

A **reality-anchored, truth-seeking epistemic constitution** makes sincere disagreement visible and keeps every person, model, authority, and institution corrigible by mind-independent reality.

A **systemic-lying epistemic constitution** organizes public speech, authority, incentives, memory, and social sanctions so that an authorized representation displaces reality and ordinary people reproduce it through conformity, concealment, and ritual participation.

Most actual societies and institutions lie somewhere between these endpoints and may occupy different positions on different dimensions. Movement toward one pole normally means movement away from the other: toward sincere avowal or compelled performance; public contestability or epistemic closure; universally binding corrigible meta-jurisdiction with bounded representatives or representatives who claim epistemic sovereignty; correction by reality or protection of the authorized model.

In its shortest form:

**The epistemic constitution is the cultural operating system that determines whether society's shared world remains answerable to reality or reality becomes answerable to society's authorized story.**

## Long semantic definition

### 1. General meaning

An **epistemic constitution of lifted mechanical solidarity** is the operative ensemble of second-order norms, sentiments, roles, authorities, institutions, incentives, procedures, communication practices, and everyday habits through which a differentiated society:

- distributes the authority to know, interpret, certify, teach, remember, and correct;
- establishes what may enter public consideration as evidence;
- shapes the relationship between private judgment and public avowal;
- makes some forms of trust, doubt, disagreement, and inquiry honourable and others shameful;
- converts dispersed observations and judgments into public knowledge or public appearance;
- preserves or destroys independent routes by which claims can be tested;
- rewards correction or protects institutions from correction;
- directs collective attention and memory;
- and determines whether social authorization remains subordinate to truth or substitutes for it.

As a second-order meta-order it has universal jurisdiction over the constitution, allocation, limitation, interaction, succession, appeal, and correction of first-order outputs and jurisdictions. This is one application of its more basic form: installed meta-rules combine with current inputs and a situation to generate a binding answer. Plural institutions and ways of life are possible outputs, not the definition of lifting. The constitution fully occupies the cultural slot whether it is reality-anchored or systemic-lying; corrigibility must be assessed separately from order level, occupancy, and jurisdiction.

The word **constitution** is used functionally rather than narrowly legally. The constitution may partly be written into laws and formal procedures, but much of it is enacted through professional norms, schooling, media routines, prestige, sanctions, language, rituals, algorithms, reputations, and the anticipated judgment of others. It is what society actually runs, not merely what its formal declarations say it runs.

An epistemic constitution is therefore not a catalogue of officially correct propositions. It is the deeper order that determines:

who may say what, through which channels, under which burdens, with which social consequences, subject to which tests, and with what possibility of correction.

This usage has a close contemporary neighbour in [Jonathan Rauch's \*The Constitution of Knowledge\*](#), which describes a liberal social system for turning disagreement into knowledge. The present term is broader and not identical. It

treats *epistemic constitution* as a neutral genus that can name truth-seeking and systemic-lying orders alike, and it connects that genus to Durkheimian solidarity, cultural formation, public sincerity, distributed enforcement, and the possibility of an entire society becoming organized around an authorized unreality.

## 2. Semantic anatomy

**Epistemic** **Epistemic** concerns the social production, communication, justification, testing, preservation, and correction of belief and knowledge. It includes empirical claims but is not limited to formal science. Historical memory, testimony, journalism, professional judgment, institutional records, public explanations, causal stories, and ordinary reports of experience all belong to the epistemic life of society.

**Constitution** **Constitution** means the relatively durable meta-rules by which epistemic life is organized. These rules allocate permissions, burdens, protections, jurisdictions, and sanctions. They need not have been designed by one actor. They may emerge recursively from many locally rational choices and then constrain the individuals who reproduce them.

These meta-rules may govern universally at their own level while generating particular answers and bounded authorities. The full definition, concrete cases, and difficult classifications remain in *Epistemic Agency under Mechanical Solidarity*.

The term should not be confused with **Michel Foucault's regime of truth**, developed in interviews such as "Truth and Power" in *Power/Knowledge*, although there is an important family resemblance. Foucault directs attention to the procedures, institutions, sanctions, and authorized speakers through which statements function as true. The present concept asks the additional realist and normative question: **does that social regime preserve independent ways for reality to defeat its authorized claims?** An epistemic constitution is therefore evaluated not only by how truth-status is socially produced but by whether the resulting order remains reality-answerable.

**Mechanical solidarity** **Mechanical solidarity**, introduced by **Émile Durkheim** in *De la division du travail social*, is cohesion through shared beliefs, sentiments, and the moral force of collective consciousness. Durkheim contrasts it analytically with **organic solidarity**, which arises through differentiation, specialization, and interdependence.

The present synthesis does not claim that modern society simply returns to undifferentiated mechanical solidarity. Modern society remains organically differentiated: physicians, engineers, historians, courts, laboratories, media, families, religious communities, firms, and citizens perform different functions and possess different knowledge.

Within the coordinated theory family, *Epistemic Agency under Mechanical Solidarity* further interprets mechanical solidarity as emergent symbolic-affective field coherence among local bigOthers, with back-action upon the people who sustain it. This document does not repeat or depend upon the physical analogies used to explain that mechanism. It takes the resulting second-order social order as its object and asks whether its epistemic constitution preserves or disables correction by reality.

**Lifted** **Lifted** names a proposed transformation of mechanical solidarity. Binding sameness moves from shared concrete rules and answers to a shared generator:

FIRST-ORDER MECHANICAL SOLIDARITY

members share concrete rules and answers R1, R2, R3 ...

↓ lifting

LIFTED MECHANICAL SOLIDARITY

members share fixed M; current K<sub>t</sub> and situation C generate binding R<sub>t</sub>(C)

*Fixed* means operatively installed and binding, not eternal. Generator and output belong to one operative weave. The result often has less shared concrete content and greater reach because one generator can produce many answers. It can protect pluralism by making different outputs compatible with membership. It can also synchronize a society around a closed generator whose authorized procedure controls what may count as real.

**Lifted** therefore describes the order at which binding sameness resides, not incomplete occupancy, weak jurisdiction, pluralism, or moral quality. A lifted program fully occupies the single slot. Its generator may govern universally at its own level even while the outputs and representatives it constitutes are bounded. It can remain open and corrigible or become closed and pathological.

The phrase **lifted mechanical solidarity** is therefore an extension of Durkheim, not a term found in his work. First-order and lifted solidarity use the same field-forming mechanism in the present theory; *lifted* means that common

binding force has moved from concrete answers to their generator. The detailed definition, examples, and boundary from organic differentiation remain in [Epistemic Agency under Mechanical Solidarity](#).

3. Why the concept is an operating system

The operating-system metaphor identifies the level at which the concept works. An epistemic constitution does not itself contain all social knowledge. It governs how knowledge-producing and belief-forming processes obtain access, communicate, compete, record results, handle error, and recover from failure.

Like an operating system, the meta-order is universal over permissions and process boundaries while the processes remain differentiated. Universality at this level does not imply one central programmer, one institutional brain, or unlimited competence for any process or administrator.

| Operating-system function | Epistemic-constitutional equivalent                                                                          |
|---------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Kernel                    | Mind-independent reality and its reserved capacity to contradict every model                                 |
| Permissions               | Domain limits on authority; rights to question, answer, inspect, and appeal                                  |
| Processes                 | Persons, disciplines, institutions, professions, communities, and inquiries                                  |
| Interfaces                | Public language, media, education, testimony, reports, debates, and records                                  |
| Sensors                   | Observation, experience, disagreement, failed predictions, adverse outcomes, and anomalies                   |
| Logs                      | Provenance, evidence, decision reasons, minority reports, predictions, corrections, and institutional memory |
| Fault isolation           | Independent sources, institutions, methods, and causal routes that reduce common-mode failure                |
| Recovery                  | Retraction, reconsideration, appeal, replication, model revision, and honourable mind-changing               |
| Resource management       | Stewardship of finite public attention and resistance to informational flooding                              |
| User protection           | Dignity, cognitive liberty, due process, legitimate dissent, and practical possibilities of exit             |

The metaphor must not imply a central programmer or a single institutional brain. The epistemic constitution is distributed. Its implementation uses several levels defined more fully in [Culture Mechanics](#) and [Epistemic Agency under Mechanical Solidarity](#):

| Core construct                     | Limited function needed here                                                                                                                                                                                                      |
|------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Lacan’s big Other</b>           | The shared symbolic order and, in the present functional translation, the on-the-wire protocol of language, law, roles, conventions, master signifiers, and recognized symbolic authority. This does not exhaust Lacan’s concept. |
| <b>Local bigOther</b>              | The individual sentiment classifier that executes an installed mythological lens and makes approval, shame, legitimacy, loyalty, and exclusion affectively operative.                                                             |
| <b>Mechanical-solidarity field</b> | Emergent coherence among compatible local bigOthers that acts back through public expectations, sanctions, institutions, and apparent consensus.                                                                                  |
| <b>Distributed bigOther</b>        | The dynamically maintained symbolic-affective network state reproduced through local bigOthers, institutions, roles, practices, stories, and artifacts.                                                                           |

| Core construct         | Limited function needed here                                                                                                                                                                                         |
|------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Multi-mind-self</b> | The distributed system only when it becomes sufficiently integrated and continuous to qualify as a collective agent. An epistemic constitution does not require every society or institution to pass this threshold. |

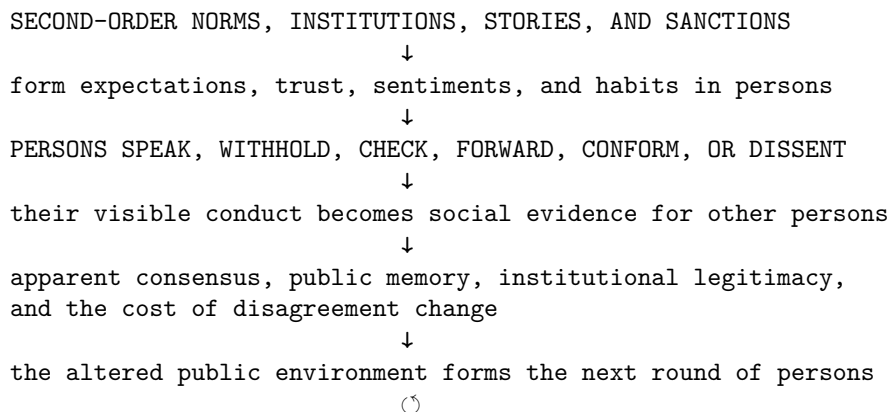
The spelling *bigOther* marks the culture-mechanical adaptation; it should not be attributed to Jacques Lacan. These distinctions specify the implementation interface without making the truth/systemic-lying analysis depend upon the full homo-duplex architecture, field analogies, privileged programming topology, or collective-ownership hypothesis. An epistemic constitution can be described and evaluated by its rules of authority, avowal, evidence, disagreement, memory, attention, and correction even where those deeper mechanisms remain disputed.

The constitution is installed when people learn not only propositions but sentiments such as:

- whether asking an elementary question is responsible or insolent;
- whether disagreement signifies integrity or betrayal;
- whether checking an ally's claim is honourable or disloyal;
- whether uncertainty signifies honesty or weakness;
- whether correction earns respect or humiliation;
- whether an accusation demands evidence or immediate alignment;
- whether an institution's prestige supplements evidence or replaces it.

#### 4. The recursive culture-mechanical cycle

The epistemic constitution forms individuals, and individuals reproduce the epistemic constitution. The causal structure is recursive:



In the core vocabulary, visible conduct is encoded through the shared symbolic protocol, reproduced as part of the distributed *bigOther*, and returned to persons as field back-action. The **epistemic constitution is not identical with that field**. It is the comparatively durable epistemic rule-pattern carried by the field and its institutions: which signals receive authority, which contradictions remain admissible, which memories persist, and how correction occurs.

No conspiracy is required. An epistemic constitution can arise through ordinary socialization, coordination, career incentives, reputational concern, information overload, sincere belief, institutional inertia, and people's reasonable need to rely on others. Deliberate actors can nevertheless exploit the same mechanisms.

This is why small individual acts matter constitutionally. A forwarded claim, concealed doubt, ritual affirmation, honest correction, elementary check, or refusal to repeat a statement can alter the public signal to which others respond.

#### 5. Epistemic dependence without epistemic surrender

Modern people cannot verify everything personally. **John Hardwig's "Epistemic Dependence"** argues that rational knowledge often depends essentially on other knowers. **Patrick Wilson's *Second-Hand Knowledge*** explains *cognitive*

authority: why some people are recognized as proper influences on what others believe. [Linda Trinkaus Zagzebski's Epistemic Authority](#) develops a positive account of rational authority and epistemic preemption.

The present synthesis borrows from these sources but makes a distinction they do not formulate in this exact way:

**Reliance:** “This person’s or institution’s judgment is important evidence that I should normally weight heavily.”

**Reality-permission:** “This person’s or institution’s judgment determines which evidence I am permitted to recognize.”

The first can be rational epistemic dependence. The second is [authority-gated belief updating](#), the proposed pathological term defined in [Epistemic Agency under Mechanical Solidarity](#) for the point at which authorization begins to govern admissibility before content is examined. This document applies that person–authority mechanism at constitutional scale; it does not redefine it.

A reality-anchored constitution does not abolish expertise. It makes authority:

- domain-limited for particular persons and institutions within the universal meta-order;
- earned and track-record-sensitive rather than purely status-conferred;
- transparent about source, method, uncertainty, and conflict of interest;
- open to criticism from independent causal routes;
- able to coordinate action without claiming ownership of empirical truth;
- corrigible without requiring institutional self-destruction.

The central constitutional maxim is:

**No person or institution receives root access to reality.**

This maxim limits representatives, not the scope of the constitution. Universal meta-jurisdiction determines how authority is allocated and corrected; it does not give parliament, a court, an expert body, or any other representative universal epistemic competence or the power to make reality answer to its certification.

**6. Sincerity precedes collective truth-seeking**

A person may sincerely express a false belief. Conversely, a person may insincerely repeat a proposition that happens to be factually correct. Public sincerity and objective truth are therefore distinct dimensions:

|                              | Proposition tracks reality             | Proposition does not track reality    |
|------------------------------|----------------------------------------|---------------------------------------|
| <b>Sincerely expressed</b>   | Knowledge or truth-tracking belief     | Honest error                          |
| <b>Insincerely expressed</b> | Correct conformity or strategic assent | Deception, false compliance, or lying |

The first constitutional task is not to certify the speaker’s belief as true. It is to preserve fidelity between public avowal and private judgment so society can discover what its members actually observe, believe, doubt, and misunderstand. Only then can those sincerely represented beliefs be tested against reality.

This yields a two-stage principle:

1. **Avowal fidelity:** let people truthfully say what they think is true, false, doubtful, or unknown.
2. **Reality fidelity:** expose those sincerely expressed judgments to evidence, criticism, experience, prediction, and correction.

In compact form:

**Say what you actually believe; submit what you believe to reality; truthfully say what you believe after reality changes it.**

[Timur Kuran’s Private Truths, Public Lies](#) supplies the central micro-to-macro mechanism of **preference falsification**: public expression can diverge from private preference under social pressure. His analysis also connects falsified public performance to impoverished public knowledge and hidden political fragility. The present framework extends Kuran’s problem from preferences to the broader sincerity conditions of public epistemic life.

The resulting pathological loop is:

- private doubt
- fear of reputational or material penalties
- public conformity
- appearance of consensus
- stronger pressure on remaining dissenters
- concealment of evidence and arguments
- corruption of public knowledge
- altered private knowledge and socialization
- deeper conformity or an unpredictable preference cascade

Public conformity thus corrupts what may be called **public epistemic telemetry**: the signals through which society tries to perceive its own distributed observations and judgments. This expression is proposed here; it is not Kuran's term.

## 7. Living within the lie and ordinary participation

The systemic-lying pole is sustained not only by authors of official falsehoods. It depends upon ordinary people repeatedly acting as if the authorized representation were true.

**Václav Havel's** *The Power of the Powerless* describes "living within a lie": public ritual and conformity reproduce a system even when participants do not believe its claims. **Aleksandr Solzhenitsyn's** "*Live Not by Lies*" formulates the individual refusal to let organized falsehood operate through one's own speech and conduct. **Lisa Wedeen's** *Ambiguities of Domination* analyzes public dissimulation in which citizens act as if they revere claims widely understood to be fictitious. **Hannah Arendt's** essays collected in *On Lying and Politics* examine factual truth, political lying, self-deception, and organized deceit.

These authors are antecedents, not co-authors of the present term. They illuminate a constitutional principle:

A systemic lie becomes a social order when people need not believe it privately but must orient public action, speech, and status as though it were true.

**Rod Dreher's** *Live Not by Lies* later borrows Solzhenitsyn's title and applies lessons from Christian dissidents to his own diagnosis of contemporary soft totalitarianism. Dreher is relevant to dissident formation and the social cost of truthfulness, but neither his political diagnosis nor his theological commitments define the regime-neutral concept developed here.

## 8. Truth as reality's reserved right of correction

The positive pole affirms that something exists independently of authorization, discourse, and collective preference. Objective truth is the regulative target, although human access to it remains fallible, partial, socially distributed, and corrigible.

The model-centred control loop is developed in *The Normal Metaphysics and Epistemology: Holistic Structural Realism*. Its core sequence is:

- experience and observation
- concepts and operations
- models or "digital twins"
- predictions and interventions
- encounter with mind-independent reality
- surprise, error, and out-of-sample consequences
- revision of models, concepts, or operations

The epistemic constitution generalizes this correction loop beyond formal science. Institutions, historical narratives, causal stories, policies, public accusations, and everyday beliefs must also remain exposed—by methods proportionate to their subject matter—to disconfirming evidence and real consequences.

Truth-seeking therefore does not mean that one institution already possesses Truth. It means preserving reality's ability to say **no**.

**Objective truth exists, but no person or institution is identical with it; therefore the collective search for truth must remain plural, testable, and corrigible.**



This is the meaning of **reality-anchored**: not that every current belief is correct, but that the social order acknowledges an external referee that cannot be finally overruled by authorization.

## 9. Piety toward the real

The central virtue of the positive pole is **piety toward the real**. The phrase comes from sociologist **Robert N. Bellah's** introduction to *Émile Durkheim on Morality and Society*, where Bellah characterizes Durkheim as possessing a strong “piety toward the real.” It is Bellah’s phrase about Durkheim, not a standard Durkheimian technical term.

The present synthesis extends it into an epistemic-constitutional virtue:

- reality is not exhausted by present concepts;
- a satisfying narrative is not sufficient evidence;
- social facts may contain structures and functions invisible to first impressions;
- preferred theories must risk predictive and explanatory failure;
- consequences and surprises can defeat authorization;
- one’s own side deserves especially careful checking;
- correction is fidelity to truth rather than betrayal of identity.

Piety toward the real must be joined to Durkheim’s defense of the morally sacred person in “*L’individualisme et les intellectuels*”. The combined formula is a synthesis rather than a quotation from Durkheim:

**Respect persons unconditionally; evaluate propositions conditionally by evidence; regulate actions through justice.**

This prevents truth-seeking from becoming a license for contempt, denunciation, or coercion. Persons do not lose dignity when they are mistaken; propositions do not become true because their proponents possess dignity.

An expressive formulation of the same orientation is:

**Shine the light of objective truth into subjective darkness—without appointing anyone sovereign owner of the light.**

## 10. Communicative integrity and linguistic tricks

The epistemic constitution is enacted at the smallest scale through ordinary speech. It matters whether communication is oriented toward mutual understanding and reality or toward operative effect while preserving the appearance of communication.

This distinction resembles **Jürgen Habermas’s** contrast between communicative and strategic action and his differentiation of truth, normative rightness, and sincerity as validity claims in *The Theory of Communicative Action*. The present synthesis borrows this orientation but does not adopt Habermas’s entire theory or treat discursive agreement as sufficient for correspondence with reality.

The detailed micro-level taxonomy is maintained separately in *Linguistic Tricks: A Semantic Inventory*. That inventory covers the assertional, informational, semantic, dialogical, attributional, and contextual operations through which communication can obscure rather than illuminate. It also explains the relation between fallacy, sophism, sophistry, and the wider category of instrumental untruthfulness. Its entries are not reproduced here.

Constitutionally, the point is:

Repeated micro-violations of communicative integrity can accumulate into the normal language, reflexes, public narratives, and institutional practices of a systemic-lying order.

**Victor Klemperer’s** *The Language of the Third Reich* is a major historical antecedent for understanding how repeated official vocabulary can shape categories, habits, emotions, and culture. **Harry Frankfurt’s** *On Bullshit* identifies the distinct danger of communication indifferent to whether its content is true. Neither author supplies the complete category of instrumental untruthfulness used in the inventory.

## 11. Disagreement as social perception

A reality-anchored constitution treats consequential disagreement first as information that the social model may be incomplete—not as contamination to be removed.

The proposed **disagreement sensor** performs a limited function:



“A consequential disagreement exists. Here are the rival propositions and their actual proponents.”

It does not determine which side is true. Its positive institutional expression is a deliberately simple **public contestability infrastructure**:

DETECT A CONSEQUENTIAL DISAGREEMENT



OFFER ITS PROPONENTS AN EQUAL PUBLIC STAGE



ENABLE DISTRIBUTED PUBLIC OPINION-FORMATION



PRESERVE THE EXCHANGE AND REOPEN IT WHEN REALITY ADDS EVIDENCE

The institution is a public sensor, stage, and memory—not a public brain. It performs three primary operations.

**11.1 Detect: make the disagreement publicly legible** Candidate disagreements can enter through two simple routes:

- **open registration:** anyone may point to two consequential, genuinely incompatible public claims and request that they be placed on a visible public list;
- **attention monitoring:** widely circulating contradictory claims—including claims found in trending social-media posts—can trigger an invitation without any judgment that either claim is respectable or true.

The sensor translates a conflict among persons, affiliations, slogans, or posts into a conflict among propositions. For example:

Claim A: X is the principal cause of Y.

Claim B: X is not the principal cause of Y; Z is.

Consequences: the disagreement materially affects policy or public conduct.

Proponents: A1 and B1, or representatives selected by them.

The public list should show the proposed wording, why the claims conflict, their public reach or consequence, who has been invited, who has accepted or declined, and when the exchange will occur. Where demand exceeds available stage time, published queues, rotation, or lottery are preferable to an opaque judgment about which position deserves attention. Detection establishes only that **a disagreement exists and matters**. It confers neither truth nor moral endorsement.

**11.2 Stage: expose the rival propositions to one another and to everyone** The paradigm is television-style in reach, immediacy, and intelligibility to ordinary viewers—not an expert-only institutional process—but without television’s declaration that one participant has “won.” Its minimal form is:

1. State the opposing propositions plainly and publish the agreed or disputed wording.
2. Give the actual proponents, or representatives chosen by them, equal standing and time.
3. Allow each side to present its own positive case rather than merely answer an opponent’s framing.
4. Permit direct questions, answers, rebuttals, and concessions under transparent rules.
5. Display the sources and evidence invoked so viewers can inspect them.
6. Broadcast the complete exchange live or with equivalent mass accessibility.
7. Preserve an unedited recording, searchable transcript, source list, and any explicit predictions or unresolved cruxes.
8. Let no moderator, panel, fact-checking office, audience poll, or institution declare a winner.
9. Leave every position open to later challenge and renewed debate.

The moderator is a custodian of equal opportunity, relevance, answerability, and accurate representation—not a sovereign certifier of truth. The moderator enforces time and speaking rules, prevents interruption, keeps the exchange on the stated propositions, and ensures an opportunity to answer allegations. Fact verification remains useful for authenticating documents, quotations, dates, calculations, and provenance, but it is an instrument available to public inquiry rather than an authority standing above it.

**11.3 Public group opinion-making: judgment without an institutional judge** After the stage has supplied a common encounter, each observer forms a provisional opinion. Viewers can compare reasons, inspect the displayed sources, discuss the arguments with others, notice different evasions or contradictions, and revise their judgments. People with relevant experience can add observations and counterevidence. Later events can reopen the same disagreement.

The resulting **public group opinion** is not a verdict issued by the hosting institution. It is the changing distribution of many individual judgments after exposure to the same strongest available opposing cases. A poll may describe that distribution, but it must not manufacture an epistemic winner or imply that a majority vote creates truth.

The hoped-for group advantage comes from distributed perception: different observers notice different factual errors, missing premises, rhetorical evasions, trade-offs, and connections to experience. It depends upon access to the full exchange, diversity of perspective, and sufficient independence of judgment. If social pressure tells everyone in advance what a respectable person must conclude, the crowd ceases to supply meaningfully independent observations.

Truth therefore functions as a **centre of gravity**, not as a democratic product. Neither the institution nor the majority owns truth. The institutional contribution is to place rival claims in shared light so dispersed human judgment—and eventually further evidence from reality—can act upon them.

The compact constitutional form is:

**Detect disagreement → offer an equal public stage → let public opinion form from independent judgments → preserve the record → reopen the question when argument, evidence, or reality warrants it.**

**11.4 Concrete prior art—and the missing integration** Several existing institutions demonstrate parts of this mechanism:

| Prior art                                                 | Relevant contribution                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                       | Difference from the proposed constitutional organ                                                                                                                                                                                                                                            |
|-----------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>DEBATECON / Modern-Day Debate</b>                      | A flagship in-person conference within a self-described neutral platform that brings opposing positions into public debates on religion, politics, and science. It demonstrates the uncensored, symmetrical public stage.                                                   | It supplies the stage, but its published format is not organized around a permanent open process for detecting, registering, and revisiting consequential disagreements.                                                                                                                     |
| <b>Open to Debate</b> —formerly Intelligence Squared U.S. | Precisely framed motions, opposing sides, structured exchanges, mass distribution through broadcast and online media, and a large public archive. Its <b>Oxford-style format</b> gives both sides equal opportunity and polls the audience before and after.                | It declares the side producing the greatest audience shift the winner. The proposed organ retains the motion, symmetry, and broadcast reach but treats opinion change only as descriptive public telemetry, not as descriptive public telemetry, not a truth criterion or victory condition. |
| <b>The Soho Forum</b>                                     | Public one-on-one Oxford-style debates around a clearly stated resolution, with direct engagement, audience questions, livestreaming, and preserved recordings. It demonstrates sustained proposition-versus-proposition confrontation rather than short panel sound bites. | It also defines victory through movement in the audience vote. Its topic selection is producer-driven rather than the output of an open disagreement sensor.                                                                                                                                 |
| <b>Braver Angels Debates</b>                              | A structured, non-punitive ethos in which participants articulate what they actually believe, may express nuance or uncertainty, and seek greater understanding rather than vanquishing an opponent.                                                                        | It supplies part of the sincerity and disagreement ethos, but is designed principally as participatory small-group conversation rather than mass-broadcast public evidence testing.                                                                                                          |

These comparisons concern the organizations’ published formats; they do not imply that the organizations have never experimented with other elements. Their contributions are complementary:

**DEBATECON supplies the open conference stage; Open to Debate supplies the formal motion and mass-broadcast form; the Soho Forum supplies sustained direct engagement; Braver Angels supplies part**

**of the non-punitive ethos. The proposed public contestability infrastructure joins these to an open disagreement sensor, distributed public judgment without an official winner, preserved evidence, and renewed correction.**

The distinctive integration lies before and after the event. Existing debate producers ordinarily choose a topic and then stage it. A disagreement-sensing constitutional organ makes the detection and fair public processing of emerging consequential disagreement itself a continuing social function. After the event, it preserves the question rather than closing it with a winner.

This procedure can borrow rules from **Frans H. van Eemeren and Rob Grootendorst's** [pragma-dialectical theory of critical discussion](#). The borrowing is partial. Pragma-dialectics supplies procedures for reasonably resolving differences of opinion; the epistemic constitution adds the external requirement that even procedurally reasonable conclusions remain answerable to evidence and reality.

The institution is deliberately not a centralized public brain:

**The institution detects and stages disagreement. The public judges. Reality decides over time.**

Distributed judgment can outperform centralized judgment when observers contribute genuinely different information, perspectives, and heuristics. **Lu Hong and Scott Page's** conditional result in "[Groups of Diverse Problem Solvers Can Outperform Groups of High-Ability Problem Solvers](#)" is a relevant formal antecedent, but it must not be inflated into the claim that every crowd is wise. Diversity, sufficient competence, independence, information access, and correction are enabling conditions. A synchronized crowd can amplify shared error.

## **12. Epistemic stewardship and responsible amplification**

The individual-level virtue corresponding to public contestability is **epistemic stewardship**, with **responsible amplification** as its everyday practice. Both expressions are proposed terms in this synthesis.

**Epistemic stewardship is the disposition to treat one's power to transmit claims and allocate other people's attention as a responsibility.**

Its operational rule is:

**Verify, qualify, or withhold.**

Before forwarding a consequential claim, a person performs the simplest competent check proportionate to its reach and possible harm. This can include reading beyond a headline, identifying the original proposition, checking the date and context, following the source chain, reproducing an elementary calculation, looking briefly for serious counterevidence, and distinguishing observation, inference, prediction, opinion, and satire.

Nobody can verify everything. *Qualify* therefore matters. A person may say, "I have not verified this; I am sharing it as a question that deserves examination." The constitutional failure occurs when uncertainty is silently converted into assertion and transferred to others as if someone upstream had checked it.

Forwarding is not merely self-expression:

**To amplify a claim is to vote for what the collective mind will attend to.**

The reality-anchored cultural mapping is:

|                               |                         |
|-------------------------------|-------------------------|
| checking before amplification | → responsibility        |
| checking one's own side       | → integrity             |
| marking uncertainty           | → honesty               |
| refraining from noise         | → attentional restraint |
| correcting one's own claim    | → honour                |
| careless repeated forwarding  | → unreliability         |

This should remain a virtue and shared yardstick rather than an official score, badge, or permission system. An agency-supporting mechanical-solidarity field can make stewardship honourable through local bigOthers; it must not convert the norm into an epistemic police force or grant one institution custody of reality.

## **13. Low-cost contradiction, not low-cost condemnation**

Protecting truthful disclosure does not justify converting anonymous reporting into a system of denunciation. A reality-anchored constitution distinguishes:

- **contradicting a claim, model, record, policy, or prediction**, which should be inexpensive and widely accessible; from
- **accusing a person in a process capable of imposing serious reputational, professional, legal, or social consequences**, which must be precise, evidentially grounded, and procedurally constrained.

The compact rule is:

**Make contradiction cheap; make evidence preservable; make accusations precise; make investigation independent; make sanctions procedurally demanding; make institutional error repairable.**

This is the constitutional answer to the moralization mechanism developed in [Culture Mechanics](#). Drawing on Michael Andrick, that account shows how an exchange can move simultaneously from the issue to the person's character and from inquiry to accusation, so that a statement, omission, association, missing conformity signal, imposed marker, or attributed target label becomes an alleged disclosure of an unbearable person. The present section does not reproduce that mini-theory; it specifies the institutional barrier against turning such a character accusation directly into lost civic standing or punishment.

An anonymous discrepancy report may legitimately trigger evidence preservation, an audit, or investigation. It must not itself count as evidence of guilt. Person-directed proceedings require, in proportion to their consequences:

- specification of the alleged act and applicable rule;
- preservation and disclosure of the substance of the evidence;
- an opportunity to answer and present contrary evidence;
- separation of reporting, investigation, adjudication, and sanction;
- an explicit standard of proof and reasoned decision;
- proportionality, independent appeal, correction, and repair after error.

Due process is not only mercy toward an accused person. It is an error-correction technology. The [EU Whistleblower Directive](#), for example, couples reporter protection with protections for the implicated person's identity, presumption of innocence, right to be heard, access to the file, and effective remedy. The epistemic-constitutional principle is broader than that particular legal instrument.

A systemic-lying constitution tends to reverse the proper cost structure:

contradicting an authorized proposition → expensive  
accusing a designated opponent → cheap

A reality-anchored constitution reverses that reversal:

challenging claims → easy  
condemning persons without tested proof → difficult

#### 14. Memory, provenance, and correction

Collective memory is part of the epistemic constitution because present judgment depends upon the evidence, alternatives, predictions, failures, and earlier dissent that the public record preserves.

A reality-anchored order records:

- original sources and source chains;
- the evidence and uncertainty available when decisions were made;
- who exercised which authority and within what jurisdiction;
- reasons, predictions, and expected consequences;
- objections and minority analyses;
- subsequent outcomes, failed replications, corrections, and reversals.

A systemic-lying order instead edits memory so that the authorized account appears always to have been obvious, unanimous, successful, and morally uncontested. Past predictions disappear; failures are renamed; dissenters become invisible or retroactively illegitimate; and later generations inherit no vocabulary or evidence with which to reconstruct the excluded alternative.

Correction therefore has both present and historical forms. Retraction without preserved provenance can become another memory hole. A healthy constitution makes correction visible while retaining enough of the error history for later institutional learning.

## The two endpoints and the tension space between them

### 15. The spectrum is real but multidimensional

The two endpoints are **ideal types**: analytically clarified limiting configurations, not claims that any whole society perfectly instantiates either one. Every actual constitution is mixed. A laboratory may be highly reality-responsive while its personnel process is denunciatory; a government may preserve due process while manipulating public statistics; a dissident community may protect sincerity while installing a rival, closed epistemic authority.

The tension space is therefore multidimensional rather than a single scalar score. Nevertheless, the poles specify genuine directional oppositions. On each relevant dimension, preserving a stronger route of independent correction weakens the corresponding mechanism of systemic lying, while increasing authority-gating, compelled performance, memory control, or semantic manipulation weakens collective corrigibility.

| Dimension                  | Reality-anchored, truth-seeking pole                                                                     | Systemic-lying pole                                                                                                      |
|----------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Ontological premise        | Mind-independent reality can resist every account                                                        | Authorized representation determines socially admissible reality                                                         |
| Epistemic aim              | Active truth-seeking and improving truth-tracking                                                        | Operative effectiveness, loyalty, control, or preservation of the system                                                 |
| Public avowal              | Belief, doubt, uncertainty, and revision may be sincerely expressed                                      | Performative conformity is safer than honest expression                                                                  |
| Authority                  | Universal corrigible meta-jurisdiction with plural, transparent, defeasible, and bounded representatives | Representatives monopolize the meta-order, become self-certifying or preemptive, and spill beyond allocated jurisdiction |
| Evidence                   | Content and provenance remain independently inspectable                                                  | Authorization controls admissibility and weight before examination                                                       |
| Disagreement               | A social sensor and legitimate route to correction                                                       | A sign of ignorance, contamination, disloyalty, or danger                                                                |
| Discussion                 | Opposing propositions receive a visible and equal stage                                                  | Deplatforming, weak opponent selection, ritual consultation, or authorized verdict                                       |
| Correction                 | Mind-changing, retraction, and concession can be honourable                                              | Correction threatens status; failures are denied, renamed, or forgotten                                                  |
| Public telemetry           | Visible speech approximately represents distributed judgment                                             | Preference and knowledge falsification manufacture apparent consensus                                                    |
| Language                   | Meanings and burdens remain explicit and contestable                                                     | Linguistic tricks, euphemism, semantic drift, and sophistry steer interpretation                                         |
| Attention                  | Responsible amplification and prioritization of consequential disagreement                               | Flooding, outrage competition, repetition, and noise exhaust checking capacity                                           |
| Memory                     | Provenance, predictions, dissent, and correction histories are preserved                                 | Records are selectively erased, rewritten, or detached from context                                                      |
| Person-directed accusation | Precise allegations, tested evidence, due process, appeal, and repair                                    | Cheap denunciation, vague charges, asymmetric secrecy, and irreversible stigma                                           |
| Institutional structure    | Independent causal routes reduce common-mode failure                                                     | Synchronization makes nominally separate bodies reproduce one protected account                                          |
| Membership                 | Persons retain dignity while claims remain conditional                                                   | Belonging, virtue, and factual assent become fused                                                                       |
| Everyday participation     | Members check, qualify, dissent, and correct                                                             | Members forward, conceal, perform, sanction, and normalize the authorized account                                        |

## 16. Reality-anchored, truth-seeking epistemic constitution

**reality-anchored, truth-seeking epistemic constitution** *noun phrase* **Status:** positive ideal type and proposed synthetic term

**Short definition** A reality-anchored, truth-seeking epistemic constitution is a social meta-order that affirms mind-independent reality, protects sincere expression and visible disagreement, organizes a plural search for objective truth, and preserves independent routes by which persons, claims, authorities, institutions, memories, and policies can be corrected.

It is a full lifted capture and a universal meta-order. Its reality-anchoring lies not in incomplete authority but in binding corrigibility: no authorized interpreter receives epistemic sovereignty, and independent reality retains the final right of refusal.

**Constitutive properties** Its defining properties are:

1. **Realism:** something exists independently of authorization and collective preference.
2. **Fallibilism:** every human model and authority may be mistaken.
3. **Truth-seeking:** inquiry actively attempts to discover what is the case rather than merely professing respect for truth.
4. **Truth-tracking:** the order evaluates whether its procedures actually improve prediction, explanation, and contact with evidence.
5. **Public avowal integrity:** people can express belief, doubt, ignorance, and revision without being required to falsify their judgment.
6. **Open contestability:** consequential disagreements remain visible and their serious proponents receive standing to defend them.
7. **Corrigible dependence:** expertise and institutions remain indispensable but defeasible, externally auditable, and limited to jurisdictions allocated by the universal meta-order.
8. **Plural correction routes:** independent sources, methods, institutions, and observers reduce synchronized error.
9. **Communicative integrity:** language facilitates shared examination rather than covertly substituting operative effect for truth.
10. **Epistemic stewardship:** individuals treat amplification and collective attention as responsibilities.
11. **Due process:** contradiction is inexpensive, while consequential condemnation requires tested evidence and remedy.
12. **Honourable correction:** admitting error and changing one's mind are signs of fidelity rather than humiliation.
13. **Moral individualism:** persons retain unconditional dignity while propositions receive conditional confidence.

Its lifted mechanical solidarity is not agreement on a comprehensive worldview. It is shared honour around the conditions under which disagreement remains truth-seeking:

People like us say what we actually believe, examine what we most want to believe, give opponents a fair hearing, preserve evidence, and let reality correct us.

## 17. Systemic-lying epistemic constitution

**systemic-lying epistemic constitution** *noun phrase* **Status:** pathological ideal type and proposed synthetic term

**Short definition** A systemic-lying epistemic constitution is a social meta-order in which public communication, institutional authority, social incentives, language, memory, and routine participation are organized to reproduce an authorized representation of reality while sincere avowal, contradictory evidence, genuine disagreement, and independent correction are suppressed, distorted, ritualized, or made prohibitively costly.

It too is a full lifted capture and a universal meta-order. Its pathology lies in how its representatives and rules monopolize interpretation, block succession and correction, and make reality answerable to authorization—not in the mere fact that one second-order order governs society-wide jurisdiction rules.

**Constitutive properties** Its defining properties include:

1. **Reality substitution:** the authorized model acquires priority over what observation, prediction, and consequence reveal.

2. **Public-private divergence:** people learn to say what participation requires rather than what they believe.
3. **Ritualized assent:** performance matters more than private conviction; visible compliance confirms the system.
4. **Authority-gated updating:** source authorization determines whether evidence may count.
5. **Asymmetric epistemic permeability:** in-group claims enter easily; inconvenient evidence faces exceptional burdens.
6. **Fusion of loyalty and truth:** disagreement becomes betrayal, impurity, danger, or moral defect.
7. **Institutional synchronization:** nominally independent institutions reproduce the same classifications and common-mode failures.
8. **Semantic capture:** words, frames, causal stories, and moral labels preselect what can be perceived, blamed, or remedied.
9. **Attention exhaustion:** flooding and repetitive low-cost claims reduce society's capacity to identify and examine important disagreements.
10. **Denunciatory enforcement:** accusations against designated persons become cheap while contradiction of authorized claims becomes costly.
11. **Memory control:** failed predictions, dissent, alternative explanations, and earlier meanings disappear from the usable record.
12. **Self-sealing correction:** the institution defines criticism as proof of hostility and failure as evidence that more commitment is needed.
13. **Distributed reproduction:** ordinary people become the execution layer by forwarding, concealing, performing, rewarding, and sanctioning.

The word **lying** is broad at this pole. A systemic-lying constitution need not consist entirely of consciously false sentences. It may contain:

- true statements selected to produce a false overall model;
- sincere believers repeating culturally installed errors;
- officials indifferent to truth rather than privately certain of falsity;
- accurate propositions repeated insincerely as rituals of submission;
- euphemisms, implications, omissions, presuppositions, frames, and classifications that evade literal falsehood;
- institutions that preserve local accuracy while protecting a globally misleading narrative.

What makes the constitution systemic-lying is not the falsity of every component. It is the organization of the whole order against independent correction.

## 18. Intermediate and mixed constitutions

Everything between the endpoints consists of partial, unstable, and domain-specific combinations. Useful intermediate descriptions include:

- **truth-professing but weakly truth-tracking:** truth is praised, but predictions, audits, and correction records are poor;
- **procedurally open but socially punitive:** formal speech rights exist, but dissent carries severe informal costs;
- **sincere but reality-detached:** people speak honestly, yet inquiry lacks adequate evidence, method, or willingness to revise;
- **technically accurate but publicly insincere:** institutions possess good local knowledge while requiring ritual public assent;
- **plural but authority-gated:** several institutions exist, yet all depend on the same source, incentives, or master classification;
- **dissident but closed around successor gatekeepers:** an alternative community protects disagreement from the mainstream while its own gatekeepers preempt symmetric evaluation and correction; rivalry alone is not the pathology;
- **corrigible in ordinary cases but closed around sacred claims:** correction works until identity-defining propositions are threatened;
- **transparent but denunciatory:** records are available, yet person-directed accusation lacks symmetrical due process;
- **free-speaking but attention-corrupted:** no one is formally silenced, but flooding and algorithmic competition bury consequential disagreement.

This prevents a simplistic classification of whole societies as “truthful” or “lying.” The analytical question is always: **which mechanisms on which dimensions currently control the correction loop?**



## 19. Movement within the tension space

Movement toward the reality-anchored pole occurs when a system:

- reduces the penalty for sincere uncertainty and disagreement;
- separates personal dignity from propositional correctness;
- makes claims rather than enemies the primary unit of dispute;
- opens evidence and provenance to independent inspection;
- limits authority by domain and separates coordination from truth certification;
- creates independent correction routes and preserves minority analyses;
- stages consequential disagreements without issuing an institutional winner;
- records predictions and revisits them after outcomes occur;
- makes correction, appeal, and institutional repair visible;
- installs epistemic stewardship as an admired everyday virtue.

Movement toward the systemic-lying pole occurs when a system:

- makes public performance increasingly independent of private judgment;
- treats consensus as evidence even when expression is pressured;
- conditions admissibility on institutional or identity authorization;
- fuses moral worth, belonging, and factual assent;
- closes or synchronizes nominally independent sources;
- substitutes labels, frames, and accusations for examination;
- makes contradiction costly and condemnation cheap;
- overwhelms attention with untested claims;
- erases failed predictions and embarrassing evidence;
- rewards participants for reproducing the authorized account.

Because the cycle is recursive, early changes can compound. Sincere dissent makes disagreement visible; visible disagreement reduces isolation; reduced isolation lowers the cost of further sincerity. Conversely, public conformity creates apparent consensus; apparent consensus increases deference; deference strengthens authorities able to impose further conformity.

The two poles must therefore be kept together conceptually. Each positive safeguard is intelligible partly as the reversal of a negative mechanism, and each negative mechanism can be diagnosed by identifying the route of correction it disables.

## Normative and diagnostic summary

### 20. Core constitutional principles

1. **Reality exists independently of social authorization.**
2. **No individual or institution is identical with objective truth.**
3. **Sincere avowal is the social starting condition of collective inquiry, not proof of correctness.**
4. **Epistemic dependence is unavoidable; epistemic sovereignty is not.**
5. **A lifted constitution shares rules that generate, select, apply, and revise concrete answers; it may govern universally while producing bounded first-order jurisdictions.**
6. **Disagreement is information before it is pathology.**
7. **Contradiction should be inexpensive; condemnation should require evidence and due process.**
8. **Publicity should expose opposing propositions, not appoint an official winner.**
9. **Independent correction routes are constitutional infrastructure.**
10. **Attention is a finite epistemic commons.**
11. **Correction and mind-changing should carry honour rather than shame.**
12. **Persons deserve unconditional dignity; propositions deserve confidence proportionate to evidence.**
13. **Reality retains the final right of refusal.**

### 21. Diagnostic questions

- Can a person publicly say “I doubt,” “I do not know,” or “I changed my mind” without losing ordinary membership?
- Does public speech plausibly reveal private judgment, or mainly the anticipated cost of expression?
- Are authorities trusted because of inspectable competence and performance, or because their authorization decides admissibility?

- Can an inexpensive direct check defeat an authorized claim?
  - Are identical claims judged differently under friendly and hostile branding?
  - Are important disagreements made visible with their strongest genuine proponents?
  - Does a moderator preserve symmetry or issue epistemic verdicts?
  - Are evidence, provenance, uncertainty, predictions, dissent, failures, and corrections preserved?
  - Can institutions admit error without redefining the error or punishing the person who exposed it?
  - Do nominally independent institutions rely on genuinely independent causal routes?
  - Is checking one's own side honoured more than rapidly forwarding its claims?
  - Does an anonymous report trigger investigation or function as proof of guilt?
  - Are accusations precise, answerable, appealable, and repairable after error?
  - Does the language of care, safety, justice, science, tradition, or freedom open inquiry or terminate it?
  - What observation would make the dominant model lose confidence?
  - Who, if anyone, has been granted practical power to overrule reality?
  - Do participants share concrete rules and answers, or the rules that generate, select, apply, and revise them?
  - Which meta-rules govern the creation, allocation, limitation, interaction, succession, appeal, and correction of the first-order outputs or jurisdictions at issue?
  - Is a particular person or institution being called "universal" when only the lifted constitution has universal jurisdiction at its own level?
  - Is the constitution first-order or lifted, is the slot fully occupied, and are its rules and representatives corrigible?
- These are separate questions.

## 22. Compact formulas

Neutral genus:

**epistemic constitution = the operative social meta-order governing authority, avowal, evidence, disagreement, memory, attention, and correction**

Order and jurisdiction:

**full lifted capture → fixed M + current K<sub>t</sub> + situation C → binding R<sub>t</sub>(C); where M governs universally, it can constitute, allocate, limit, succeed, and correct first-order jurisdictions while representatives receive no root access to reality**

Positive pole:

**sincere avowal → visible disagreement → plural inquiry → encounter with reality → correction → sincere revised avowal**

Negative pole:

**social pressure → public performance → apparent consensus → authority-gated knowledge → suppressed correction → organized unreality**

Individual virtue:

**verify, qualify, or withhold**

Public contestability:

**the institution detects and stages disagreement; the public judges; reality decides over time**

Moral rule:

**respect persons unconditionally; evaluate propositions conditionally by evidence; regulate actions through justice**

Ultimate contrast:

**A reality-anchored constitution preserves reality's right to correct society. A systemic-lying constitution grants society's authorized representatives the right to correct reality.**

## Terminological provenance and boundaries

### 23. Established concepts retained substantially in their source sense

- **Mechanical and organic solidarity** — Émile Durkheim: *De la division du travail social*.
- **Epistemic dependence** — John Hardwig: “Epistemic Dependence”.
- **Cognitive authority** — Patrick Wilson: *Second-Hand Knowledge*.
- **Epistemic authority and preemption** — Linda Trinkaus Zagzebski: *Epistemic Authority*.
- **Epistemic vigilance** — Dan Sperber, Fabrice Clément, Christophe Heintz, Olivier Mascaro, Hugo Mercier, Gloria Origg, and Deirdre Wilson: “Epistemic Vigilance”. The present synthesis uses their account of vigilance toward communicated information without assuming that individual vigilance alone can repair a systemic order.
- **Preference falsification** — Timur Kuran: *Private Truths, Public Lies*. The present synthesis generalizes the problem from preference expression to public avowal and epistemic telemetry.
- **Living within the lie** — Václav Havel: *The Power of the Powerless*.
- **Refusal to participate in lies** — Aleksandr Solzhenitsyn: “Live Not by Lies”.
- **Public dissimulation and acting “as if”** — Lisa Wedeen: *Ambiguities of Domination*.
- **Political lying and factual truth** — Hannah Arendt: *On Lying and Politics*.
- **Language as culture-forming political medium** — Victor Klemperer: *The Language of the Third Reich*.
- **Critical discussion** — Frans H. van Eemeren and Rob Grootendorst: *Argumentation, Communication, and Fallacies*.

### 24. Borrowed concepts deliberately extended or modified here

| Term used here                                              | Source                                                                                                                             | Difference in the present synthesis                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                    |
|-------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Lifted mechanical solidarity</b>                         | Durkheim’s mechanical solidarity, as extended in <i>Epistemic Agency under Mechanical Solidarity</i>                               | Moves common binding force from concrete rules and answers to rules that generate, select, apply, and revise them while retaining the same proposed field-forming mechanism. Plural first-order lives are a possible result, not the definition. <i>Lifted</i> is not Durkheim’s term. |
| <b>Lacan’s big Other as shared symbolic protocol</b>        | Lacan’s locus of language, law, and symbolic authority                                                                             | “On-the-wire protocol” is the functional translation defined in <i>Culture Mechanics</i> , not Lacan’s definition or a complete exegesis.                                                                                                                                              |
| <b>Local bigOther</b>                                       | Lacan’s big Other, operationally adapted in <i>Culture Mechanics</i>                                                               | Names the individual sentiment classifier executing the mythological lens. It is neither Lacan’s symbolic order nor a synonym for the distributed bigOther.                                                                                                                            |
| <b>Mechanical-solidarity field and distributed bigOther</b> | Durkheim’s mechanical solidarity and Lacan’s big Other, synthesized in <i>Epistemic Agency under Mechanical Solidarity</i>         | Distinguishes emergent field coherence from the dynamically maintained symbolic-affective network state. These are project-developed extensions, not source-author terminology.                                                                                                        |
| <b>Multi-mind-self</b>                                      | Group-person and group-agency neighbours synthesized with culture mechanics in <i>Epistemic Agency under Mechanical Solidarity</i> | Names only a distributed system integrated enough to qualify as a continuing collective agent; it is not required for the definition of an epistemic constitution.                                                                                                                     |
| <b>Piety toward the real</b>                                | Robert Bellah’s characterization of Durkheim                                                                                       | Converts Bellah’s descriptive phrase into an explicit norm of epistemic and institutional model correction.                                                                                                                                                                            |

| Term used here                 | Source                                                                                                | Difference in the present synthesis                                                                                                                                                 |
|--------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Epistemic constitution</b>  | Neighbouring use in Jonathan Rauch's <i>constitution of knowledge</i> and broader social epistemology | Makes the term a neutral genus spanning both truth-seeking and systemic-lying social orders and joins it to lifted solidarity and culture mechanics. No claim of first use is made. |
| <b>Public avowal integrity</b> | Kuran's preference falsification and Havel's living within the lie                                    | Extends private-public fidelity from preferences and dissident ethics to belief, doubt, uncertainty, and revision across public epistemic life.                                     |
| <b>Communicative integrity</b> | Habermas's communicative action and validity claims; pragma-dialectical critical discussion           | Adds explicit reality-answerability and a broader inventory of semantic, contextual, and systemic failure modes.                                                                    |
| <b>Reality correction loop</b> | Holistic structural realism; fallibilist and scientific model testing                                 | Generalizes model-prediction-surprise-revision beyond formal science to institutions, narratives, policies, and public knowledge.                                                   |

## 25. Newly proposed terms and formulations

The following are proposed within the coordinated theory project. Some originate in the preceding entries and are applied rather than redefined here. They should not be attributed to Durkheim, Lacan, Bellah, Rauch, Kuran, Havel, Solzhenitsyn, Arendt, Wedeen, Habermas, or van Eemeren and Grootendorst unless a later independent source establishes otherwise:

- **epistemic constitution of lifted mechanical solidarity** in the exact sense defined here;
- **first-order full capture, lifted full capture**, the distinction between shared answers and a shared answer generator, and **universal jurisdiction over the allocation and limitation of first-order outputs and jurisdictions**, inherited from the coordinated theory project and applied constitutionally here;
- **reality-anchored, truth-seeking epistemic constitution**;
- **systemic-lying epistemic constitution**;
- **public epistemic telemetry**;
- **public avowal integrity** as defined here;
- **authority-gated belief updating** and **reality-permission**, inherited from *Epistemic Agency under Mechanical Solidarity* and applied at constitutional scale here;
- **disagreement sensor** and **public contestability infrastructure**;
- **epistemic stewardship** and **responsible amplification**;
- **verify, qualify, or withhold** as the stewardship formula;
- the maxim **no person or institution receives root access to reality**;
- the combined tension-space model joining all of these concepts.

## 26. Scope cautions

1. **The framework is not anti-institutional.** Modern knowledge requires institutions and rational epistemic dependence. The pathology is monopoly, opacity, spillover, preemption, synchronized error, and resistance to correction.
2. **It is not epistemic individualism.** Personal checking is proportionate and domain-sensitive. Elementary verification supplements rather than abolishes expertise.
3. **It does not identify sincerity with truth.** Honest error remains error; correct conformity remains socially fragile if nobody may express why they disagree.
4. **It does not identify consensus with truth.** Consensus can be evidence when expression is free and routes are independent; it can be manufactured telemetry when expression is pressured.
5. **It does not identify disagreement with truth.** Contrarianism may be governed by a closed or preemptive successor authority. Rivalry alone is not the defect; disagreement initiates examination but does not settle it.

6. **It does not authorize a ministry of truth.** Reality-anchoring denies final epistemic sovereignty to every institution, including institutions established in the name of truth.
7. **It does not treat every social construction as false.** Law, money, office, promise, jurisdiction, and dignity are socially constituted yet real in their operation. Empirical assertions about them and their consequences remain testable.
8. **It does not require certainty before action.** Decisions under uncertainty still consider probability, severity, justice, reversibility, and the costs of action and inaction.
9. **It does not assume deliberate conspiracy.** Systemic lying can emerge through sincere belief, conformity, dependency, attention dynamics, and institutional self-protection, although it can also be strategically exploited.
10. **It is not a partisan classification.** The same criteria apply to governments and dissidents, majorities and minorities, scientific institutions and countercultures, religious and secular communities, allies and opponents.
11. **It does not depend upon the strongest collective-mind claims of culture mechanics.** The constitutional distinction can be applied by inspecting authority, avowal, evidence, disagreement, attention, memory, and correction even if the multi-mind-self threshold, privileged programming topology, or physical field analogies remain disputed.
12. **It does not define lifting as pluralism.** A lifted order is defined by its shared answer generator. That generator may have universal jurisdiction and produce plural, domain-limited authorities; universal meta-jurisdiction is not epistemic sovereignty because no representative may determine what reality is permitted to be.

## Final semantic summary

- **Broader class:** society-wide epistemic and cultural meta-order.
- **Central object:** the relationship among reality, private judgment, public avowal, authority, evidence, disagreement, attention, memory, and correction.
- **Social form:** lifted mechanical solidarity—shared rules for generating, selecting, applying, and revising concrete answers—coexisting here with organic differentiation.
- **Slot occupancy:** reality-anchored and systemic-lying constitutions are both full lifted captures; full occupancy does not decide epistemic quality.
- **Jurisdictional form:** the lifted generator can govern universally while constituting, allocating, limiting, coordinating, and governing the succession and correction of first-order outputs and jurisdictions.
- **Authority boundary:** persons and institutions remain plural and domain-limited beneath the meta-order and receive no root access to reality.
- **Core-theory interface:** local bigOthers communicate through a shared symbolic protocol and help maintain a mechanical-solidarity field and distributed bigOther; a multi-mind-self is possible but not required.
- **Implementation:** formal institutions plus distributed cultural programming, incentives, language, habits, reciprocal social enforcement, and field back-action.
- **Starting predicament:** unavoidable epistemic dependence.
- **Positive endpoint:** reality-anchored, truth-seeking epistemic constitution.
- **Negative endpoint:** systemic-lying epistemic constitution.
- **Positive central virtue:** piety toward the real.
- **Positive interpersonal condition:** sincere avowal without immunity from correction.
- **Positive public mechanism:** visible, equal, non-sovereign staging of consequential disagreement.
- **Positive individual virtue:** epistemic stewardship in amplification.
- **Central negative recursion:** conformity → apparent consensus → deference → knowledge corruption → deeper conformity.
- **Central institutional pathology:** authority-gated belief updating and self-protected correction failure.
- **Micro-level mechanisms:** cross-referenced in [Linguistic Tricks: A Semantic Inventory](#).
- **Governing question:** Does society's authorization provide corrigible routes toward reality, or does authorization determine what reality is permitted to be?